

after my bills and major expenses, like car, rent and health insurance payments, are deducted.

We had calculated \$700 wriggle cash every two weeks, but I have been so disciplined that I am managing to pay for the necessities and get by on much less.

Certain lifestyle choices I took for granted before have become challenging. My friends know that at the start of a pay cycle, when the 'wriggle money' is abundant, we can go out for steak frites chased with a decent bottle of pinot. But by the end, it's noodles at my rented apartment with a glass of cleanskin.

I now rely on cash only to keep track of my spending. If I have \$20 left in my wallet and a takeaway coffee costs a fifth of that, I bypass the barista. And my savings are climbing, although I can't say how much, because I don't know what I have in the bank.

I asked my parents for an update after a couple of months – there was several thousand dollars sitting in the account – but I prefer to be ignorant of the balance.

I only want to be told when there is enough for a deposit on a small apartment. I think I can achieve that in two years.

My damaging relationship with money started after a health scare in my mid-20s. Six years ago, my GP found a large borderline-malignant ovarian tumour during a routine health check. All up, the treatment cost me \$10,000, after my health insurer wrongly decided my oncologist was classified as reproductive services.

At 26, saddled with a five-figure medical bill, I took about four months off my journalism job to recover from surgery. When I returned to a newsroom, I requested the fashion editor gig. It was available, I loved fashion and I needed a fresh start.

One of my first stories was to cover the David Jones fashion parade in Sydney, where I was seated next to the doyenne of Australian design, Carla Zampatti. Carla swooshed in wearing an impeccable cream suit and Jackie O-style sunglasses, and as she took her seat next to me, asked, 'I love your dress – who is it by?'

I had fished it from a \$20 sale bin the day before in a panic. I was young, on a starting salary and couldn't afford a designer kit for my debut fashion show. I was deeply embarrassed and lied to Carla, and that was the day I lost control of my finances – all in a bid to keep up appearances.